

U.S. Multi Industry & Electrical Equipment

US Multis Preview (Vertiv / nVent): Re-iterate long-term Outperform on both names but tactically prefer NVT in 3Q



Varun Govindaraj
+1 917 344 8543
varun.govindaraj@bernsteinsg.com

Specialist Sales



Steve Song
+1 917 344 8401
steve.song@bernsteinsg.com

In this preview, we cover our electrical equipment sub-segment which includes Vertiv and nVent. Our key thoughts for the quarter are laid out below.

VRT: Re-iterate our long-term Outperform, but **tactically neutral going into 3Q**. We are [not worried about alleged product / service quality issues](#), the pace of build slowing, or their ability to meet their guide in the back half of the year (where we have turned more constructive post-conference season and speaking with investors). However, the buy-side investors we have spoken to have EPS at ~\$7 for 2026 which implies HSD EPS beats are needed in 3Q and 4Q. While we are comfortable with VRT meeting their own guide, it is quite backweighted and we are unsure if they can deliver above it (at least for 3Q) which largely drives our decision to remain tactically neutral. Sentiment on the stock is fine but not stellar, investors acknowledge valuations have made it much more attractive so we're seeing some hesitance from HFs to be short going into the quarter. Most LOs continue to tell us that they'd rather wait for clarity on midterms before deploying more capital into the name (although our trading desk has told us of some LOs nibbling at this valuation to open new positions). We are largely in line with guidance and consensus for 3Q26. We forecast revenue at \$3.73B (VA consensus at \$3.76B and guidance midpoint at \$3.75B), adj. operating margins at 24.9% (VA consensus at 24.6% and guidance midpoint at 24.5%) and EPS at \$1.81 (VA consensus at \$1.82 and guidance midpoint at \$1.80). Note that we have taken up our 3Q operating margin numbers by ~40 bps since our last published model which marginally increases EPS but does not impact share price.

NVT: Our **top pick going into 3Q** (across our entire coverage). We think investors underestimate the earnings torque the company can get from liquid cooling, especially now that Rubin has started to ship. Liquid cooling will grow at a rate higher than GW added over the next 3 - 5 years as we see it gain a greater share of deployments in the future, and this is a big part of growth for NVT. We also think the multiple discount to VRT is no longer warranted (on the basis of growth / margin outlook) and expect to see convergence over the next couple of quarters. We have also seen significant interest from LOs doing the work on the name as it approaches the size that makes it interesting to larger cap managers. We are marginally more concerned on price / cost for NVT than we are for VRT given they may see weakness in the EC business, but if orders come in strong that should not be an issue. Investors we have spoken with expect to see relatively weak orders growth (~10% YoY off tough comps in 3Q25), however, given orders were weak in 2Q and tend to be lumpy, we believe some of that demand is possibly "deferred" into 3Q and we could see orders numbers come in better than expected. Even with tepid order expectations, investors seem to largely be long the stock going into the print. We are largely in line with guidance for 3Q26 as we believe this is the best indicator of numbers in a space where data is largely opaque. We forecast revenue at \$1.43B (VA consensus at \$1.42B and implied guidance midpoint at \$1.41B) and EPS at \$1.39 (VA consensus at \$1.38 and guidance midpoint at \$1.37). However, NVT is known for being conservative and investors seem to be expecting a 10%+ EPS beat on the 3Q26 guide (which does seem likely based on performance in the last couple of quarters).

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	Cur	1 Oct 2026	Price	TTM	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
			Closing	Target	Rel. Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
VRT (Vertiv)	O	USD	246.12	368.00	38.1%	USD	4.20	6.60	9.06	58.6	37.3	27.2
NVT (nVent)	O	USD	165.77	229.00	51.3%	USD	3.34	5.15	6.55	49.6	32.2	25.3
TT (Trane)	O	USD	458.94	575.00	(6.4)%	USD	13.06	15.28	17.79	35.1	30.0	25.8
JCI (Johnson Controls)	O	USD	151.77	190.00	25.1%	USD	3.78	5.09	6.35	40.2	29.8	23.9
CARR (Carrier)	M	USD	55.22	78.00	(21.4)%	USD	2.57	2.85	3.29	21.5	19.4	16.8
EMR (Emerson)	O	USD	158.57	186.00	6.6%	USD	6.00	6.55	7.23	26.4	24.2	21.9
ROK (Rockwell)	M	USD	442.45	514.00	12.4%	USD	10.47	13.13	14.53	42.3	33.7	30.4
HON (Honeywell)	M	USD	213.80	254.00	(11.2)%	USD	6.46	8.31	9.72	33.1	25.7	22.0
PH (Parker Hannifin)	O	USD	965.88	1,218.00	13.7%	USD	32.31	35.13	38.68	29.9	27.5	25.0
MMM (3M)	M	USD	163.02	171.00	(9.7)%	USD	8.06	8.91	9.62	20.2	18.3	16.9
OTIS (Otis)	O	USD	64.48	90.00	(44.4)%	USD	4.05	4.05	4.52	15.9	15.9	14.3
APH (Amphenol)	O	USD	85.67	99.00	23.2%	USD	1.67	2.65	3.31	51.3	32.3	25.9
TEL (TE Connectivity)	O	USD	217.76	243.00	(16.0)%	USD	9.26	11.46	12.98	23.5	19.0	16.8
SPX			7,666.45									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

PH base year is 2026;

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We rate VRT Outperform, TP \$368

We rate NVT Outperform, TP \$229

We rate TT Outperform, TP \$575

We rate JCI Outperform, TP \$190

We rate CARR Market-Perform, TP \$78

We rate EMR Outperform, TP \$186

We rate ROK Market-Perform, TP \$514

We rate HON Market-Perform, TP \$254

We rate PH Outperform, TP \$1,218

We rate MMM Market-Perform, TP \$171

We rate OTIS Outperform, TP \$90

We rate APH Outperform, TP \$99

We rate TEL Outperform, TP \$243

DETAILS

EXHIBIT 1: Sector overview going into 3Q26 (1/2)

Company	Current price	Target price	Fwd P/E Multiple	Rating	Tactical 3Q positioning	Tactical commentary
 VERTIV	\$246	\$368	31.2x	OP	Neutral	Concerns around meeting buy-side #s (\$7 vs. \$6.7 guide)
 nvent	\$166	\$229	28.5x	OP	Positive	Continued torque from liquid cooling ramp-up through '27
 TRANE TECHNOLOGIES	\$459	\$575	27.8x	OP	Neutral	Concerns around price cost in 3Q/4Q
 Johnson Controls	\$152	\$190	25.9x	OP	Positive	Expect strong FY27 guide from JCI
 Carrier	\$55	\$78	18.0x	MP	Neutral	No near-term catalysts (margin & resi. are overhangs)
 Amphenol	\$86	\$99	29.0x	OP	Positive	Continued torque from in-rack DC outperformance
 TE connectivity	\$218	\$243	17.4x	OP	Neutral	Do not expect strong orders to convert till 2027

Focus of this note

U.S. MULTI-INDUSTRY & ELECTRICAL EQUIPMENT EXHIBIT 2: Sector overview going into 3Q26 EPS (2/2)

Company	Current price	Target price	Fwd P/E Multiple	Rating	Tactical 3Q positioning	Tactical commentary
Emerson	\$159	\$186	22.4x	OP	Neutral	No imminent catalyst; expect conservative guide
 Honeywell Technologies	\$214	\$254	23.4x	MP	Positive	We think growth could be above higher end of guide
 Rockwell Automation	\$442	\$514	30.4x	MP	Neutral	Price cost concerns; FY27 guide / investor day are key catalysts
 Parker	\$966	\$1218	27.2x	OP	Positive	Short-cycle support + aero. aftermarket better than expected
 OTIS	\$64	\$90	15.3x	OP	Neutral	Near-term overhang from ongoing CEO transition
 3M	\$163	\$171	17.6x	MP	Positive	Short-cycle support + possible targets on GM expansion

Source: Bernstein Analysis and Estimates, Visible Alpha, Company Reports

VERTIV

Going into the 3Q print, we re-iterate our preference for VRT over a longer-term (3 - 5 year) period **but remain tactically neutral** for this quarter.

Vertiv has seen significant volatility post 2Q, even more than other AI industrials (who themselves saw a lot of de-rating and churn). Three major incidents stand out in particular; (i) the 2Q organic growth miss (due to shipment delays) saw the stock down almost 20% on the day, (ii) the Semianalysis note alleging product / service quality issues caused significant consternation with another ~15% drop over a couple of days closely followed by [Dario Amodè's letter](#) calling for the pace of the frontier to slow further adding fuel to the fire with another ~10% drop. In addition, (iv) price cost also continues to show up as a theme investors are worried about for industrials more broadly. Our perspectives on each of these issues are discussed in more detail below.

Shipments: We were initially skeptical of Vertiv's ability to meet their back half weighted guide. We are now more comfortable with it and think they are unlikely to miss. The issue was with modular SmartRun / OneCore solutions required material supply chain coordination to ensure everything was ready for integration before revenue could be recognized. While we generally do not think supply chain issues can go away overnight, the fact that these were internal coordination issues vs. problems with external suppliers does make it seem more feasible to get a near-term resolution. Management also sounded quite optimistic on the conference circuit and investor meetings on their ability to meet this goal. Most (but not all) investors we've spoken to agree with us on this. Our tactical concern is driven more by their ability to **BEAT** the guide. Buyside EPS (at least from investors we have spoken with) seem to be around \$7 in 2026 vs. the midpoint of VRT's guide which is \$6.7. This implies a ~7.5% EPS beat needed in the back half of the year. And while we do think they will meet their guide, it is aggressive (unlike a few other names in the DC space where investors clearly think management is sandbagging) so HSD outperformance on EPS needs everything to go right which makes us a bit nervous.

Product / service quality: We re-iterate our belief that product quality is not an enduring issue at VRT. Our recent channel check on the topic largely strengthened our earlier POV that things are not bad at all. Our more detailed notes on the topic can be viewed [here](#) and [here](#). Yes, there are some growing pains associated with venturing into new products / the rapid growth (QA/QC, etc.) but our conversations with hyperscalers indicate this is not VRT specific. Hyperscalers also mentioned that when these issues do arise, VRT is responsive and good to work with on resolving them. Service quality was flagged as a strength from our channel checks, and we expect to see Vertiv continuing to build this organization as they grow.

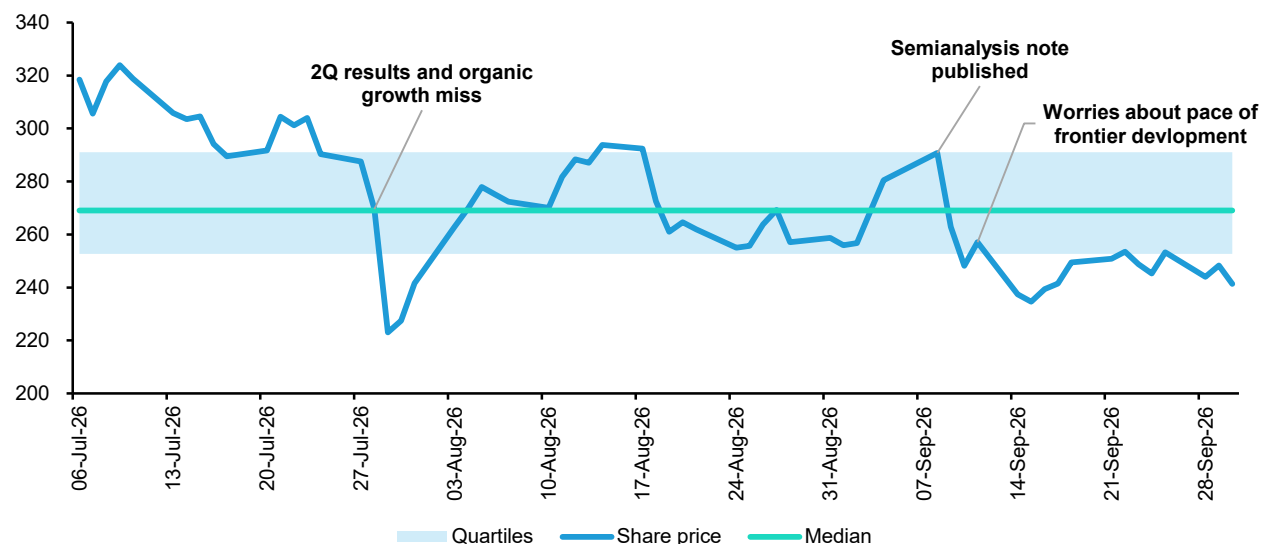
Pace of frontier slowing: We do not think this is a real concern. While it created a stir for most equipment names when Anthropic's CEO published their note, most investors (as well as hyperscaler employees we've spoken with) seem to think this is more talk than action. Clearly governments do not support a slowdown and given this is a winner-take-most market, it's hard for us to see why any company would voluntarily slow their pace of development when they cannot reliably believe their competition would do the same.

Price cost: We are largely unconcerned on price / cost for companies that have most of their revenue from DCs. While this varies by contract / customer, there are generally escalation clauses linked to input prices so even with steel marching north we think Vertiv is relatively well-protected on this front.

Sentiment: From our conversations, sentiment has been neutral. Most LO industrial investors are waiting for the mid-terms to end before deploying more capital into the space. From our sample set, HFs are not actively shorting VRT at this price (outside of investors in the AI value chain space that are short electrical equipment more broadly vs. sectors like semis / memory). From our trading desk, we've heard of some nervousness from investors on opening new shorts; when it does happen it tends to be a relatively short-lived position vs. something more enduring. Valuation is certainly seen as tempting given there isn't a huge gap with non-AI industrials after the de-rating since VRT does offer a great growth outlook.

Our view on the numbers: We are largely in line with guidance and consensus for 3Q26. We forecast revenue at \$3.73B (VA consensus at \$3.76B and guidance midpoint at \$3.75B), adj. operating margins at 24.9% (VA consensus at 24.6% and guidance midpoint at 24.5%) and EPS at \$1.81 (VA consensus at \$1.82 and guidance midpoint at \$1.80). Our numbers imply incremental margins of ~31%.

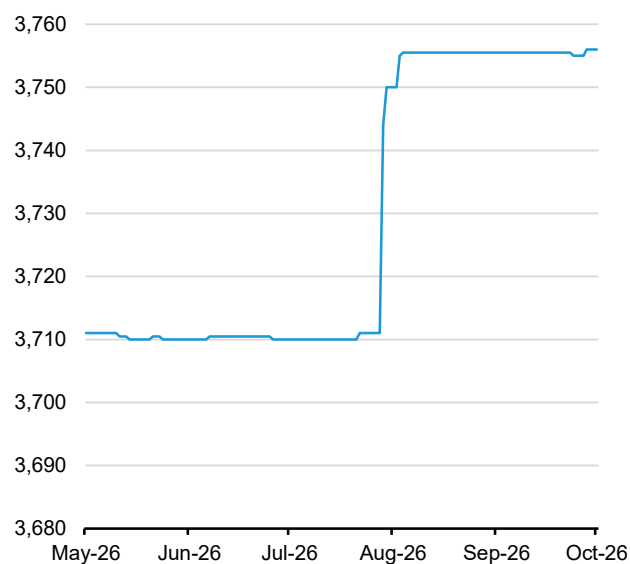
EXHIBIT 3: VRT share price evolution past 3 months



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 4: VRT Consensus revenue evolution (next reporting quarter)

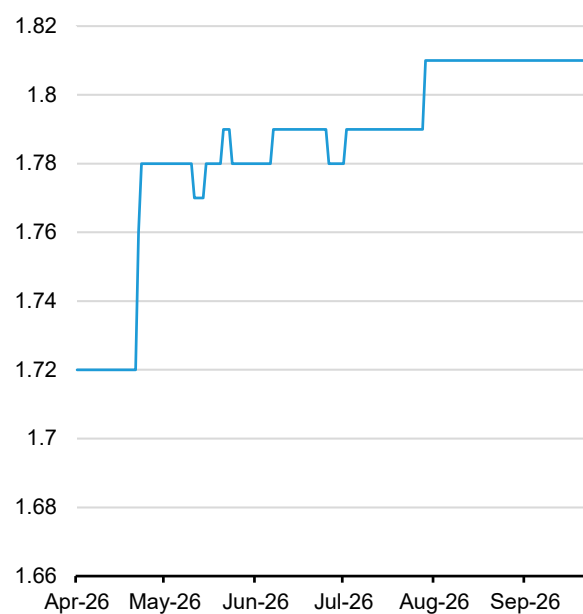
\$M



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

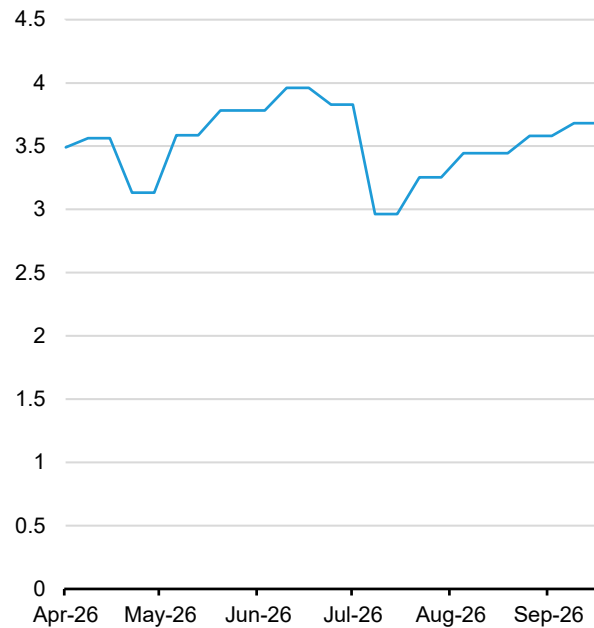
EXHIBIT 5: VRT Consensus EPS evolution (next reporting quarter)

\$



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

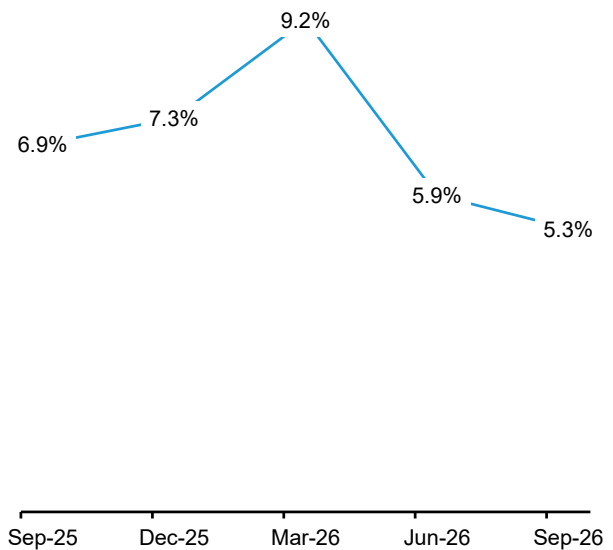
EXHIBIT 6: VRT short interest as % of total float



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

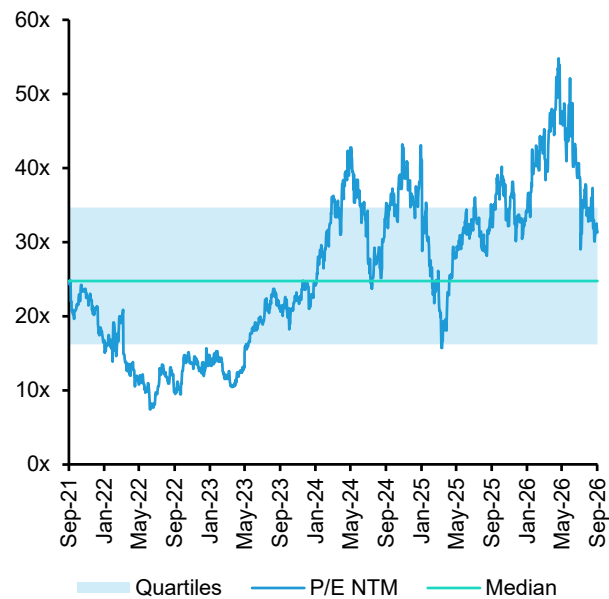
EXHIBIT 7: VRT hedge fund managers ownership

Based on publicly reported holdings



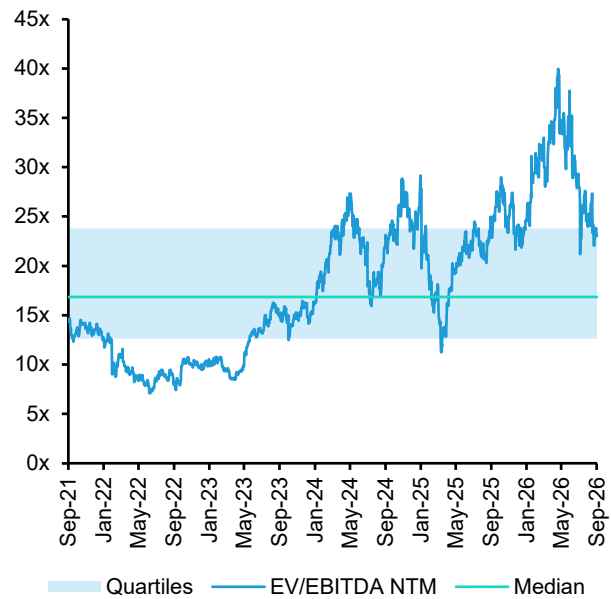
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 8: VRT P/E NTM



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: VRT EV/EBITDA NTM



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

U.S. MULTI-INDUSTRY & ELECTRICAL EQUIPMENT

EXHIBIT 10: **VRT Cons. vs Reported**

\$m

	Revenue reported	Revenue Cons.	Diff (Report. vs Cons.)	Adj. EBIT reported	EBIT Cons.	Diff (Report. vs Cons.)	Dil EPS reported (\$)	Dil EPS Cons.(\$)	Diff (Report. vs Cons.)	Price change on result day
2024 Q3	2,074	1,980	5%	417	387	8%	0.76	0.69	11%	-4%
2024 Q4	2,346	2,159	9%	504	442	14%	0.99	0.83	19%	-10%
2025 Q1	2,036	1,934	5%	337	329	2%	0.64	0.60	7%	9%
2025 Q2	2,638	2,358	12%	489	442	11%	0.95	0.83	14%	1%
2025 Q3	2,676	2,580	4%	596	514	16%	1.24	0.98	27%	-2%
2025 Q4	2,880	2,882	0%	668	650	3%	1.36	1.29	5%	24%
2026 Q1	2,650	2,630	1%	551	505	9%	1.17	1.01	16%	-2%
2026 Q2	3,274	3,377	-3%	738	720	3%	1.52	1.42	7%	-17%

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

NVENT

nVent is our **top pick of our entire coverage of ~13 stocks**, both tactically as well as over a 3 - 5 year time period. We continue to think this is an underappreciated data center story.

Liquid cooling: We think the market underappreciates the impact liquid cooling will have on growth for NVT. It is adding material capacity, effectively going from barely any liquid cooling to 400k square feet in a span of three years (Anoka in 2025, Blaine 1 this year, and Blaine 2 in 2027), all of which are being setup based on robust demand they are seeing from customers. With Vera Rubin starting to ship in 2H26, we should also see growth over GW as mix shifts from air-cooled to liquid-cooled racks. We continue to think they are also weighted to hyperscalers as customers (with some colos) which indicates "high quality" demand that is unlikely to see cancellation.

Orders and backlog: There was some stress among investors last quarter around order numbers slowing and backlog marginally declining sequentially; while it is hard to predict where these numbers will land due to broader opacity in the space, we expect to see a re-acceleration (supported by management commentary on the 2Q call on 3Q orders being off to a strong start). From our conversations with investors, we've heard their expectations of orders being up ~10% YoY vs. tough comps in 3Q25 (where NVT was up 65%). We think that there is room for NVT to beat those expectations; given 2Q was weak and NVT is exposed to lumpier hyperscaler orders, we think some of this ends up materializing in 3Q. In addition, NVT has new liquid cooling capacity online that wasn't last year, which also just sets up a larger asset base for the company to take orders against.

Relative valuation vs VRT: We think NVT will re-rate in the next 6 months to bridge (or at least narrow) their valuation gap with VRT. NVT is ~40% data center revenues vs. VRT which is double that share if not >90% data center revenues. When we set our multiples, we do so on the basis of forward looking growth and margins. NVT is guiding organic growth up 33% in 2026 at the midpoint (which the market broadly sees as very conservative) while VRT is guiding organic growth up 31% at the midpoint (which most investors do not expect to see a major beat on). Growth will taper eventually, but should taper less aggressively for NVT since it will see a mix shift on growth (every quarter will have a higher share of the business being relatively faster growing as DC revenue continues to expand). On margins, we also see no reason why NVT's SP business margins do not eventually converge with VRT (while the structurally higher margin EC business also supports the mix). So while there has been a persistent 3 - 5x turn fwd P/E discount between the names, we think that is very temporary. We think the catalyst here will be LO capital flows. We've continued to receive interest from LOs doing initial work on the stock as it approaches a market cap where larger cap managers can start to own the name. If they continue to deliver beats like they have over the last couple of quarters, we'd be surprised to not see this re-rating play out over the next ~6 months or so.

Price cost: We are largely unconcerned on price / cost for companies that have most of their revenue from DCs. On the margin for NVT, we think we could see some margin weakness in the Electrical Connections business. Metal prices continue to rise and while NVT does see this impact play out with a lag, it will still play out. That being said, we think investors will be largely forgiving of any margin weakness on the EC side as long as orders / organic growth / SP margins are strong (which we expect them to be).

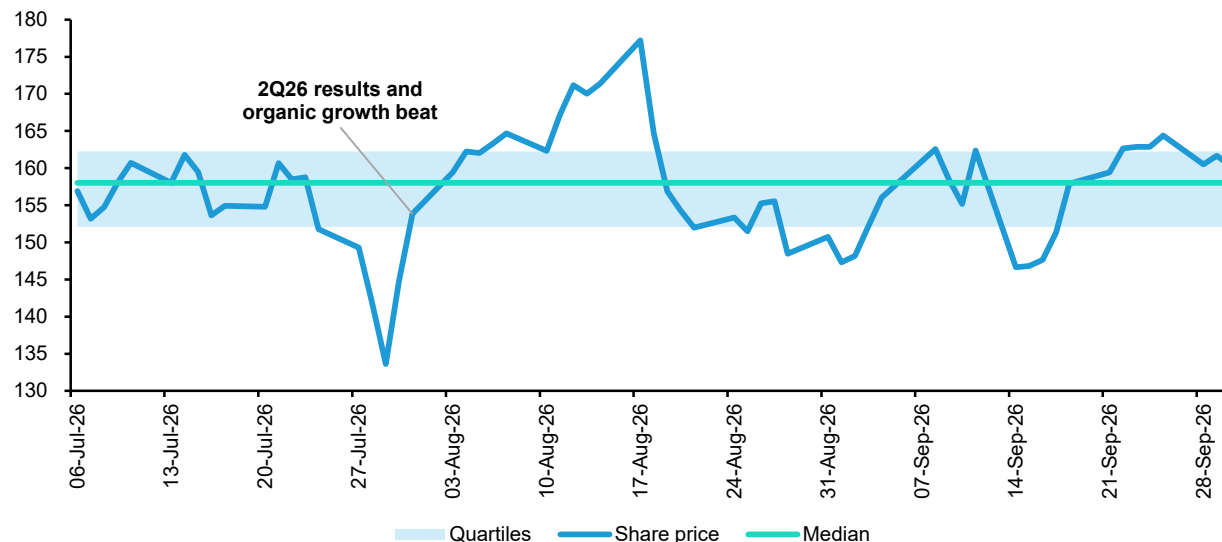
Maverick and modular: While not relevant to the quarter, we also like NVT's acquisition of Maverick. At it's core, we think the deal brings three things to NVT (at an extremely reasonable price). First, it strengthens their switchgear portfolio which is key to their modular / e-house offering. Second, it adds service teams (based in Texas) which is critical to creating longevity when capex eventually slows. Finally, it also brings in more engineering talent on the power side to support product development. Modular, along with liquid cooling, is the second large shift that electrical equipment players in the data center space stand to benefit from and we think NVT is again in early days of seeing this play out. As a side note, while we mention in our [earlier publication](#) that this deal would also add UPS capabilities to NVT, our conversations with management indicate that this is just a much smaller part of the Maverick story.

Sentiment: Very positive reads from investors who mostly seem to be long going into the print. As with Vertiv, there are a few sector-led shorts where it is mostly a trade going long semis / memory and short equipment names more broadly. As mentioned earlier, there are multiple larger capitalization LOs actively doing groundwork on the name and looking to initiate positions.

Our view on numbers: In higher, lumpy growth markets like data centers, we think management guidance offers us the best view of where numbers will land. With that said, NVT is known for being conservative (as seen by how each quarter is a big beat and raise) so we do expect our estimates to be lighter vs. actual results. The buy-side also knows this, so expectations are for an 10%+ beat over where the sell-side sits on EPS. If the last few quarters are any indicator, this is likely to happen. With that said, we are largely in line with guidance and consensus for 3Q26. We forecast revenue at \$1.43B (VA consensus at \$1.42B and

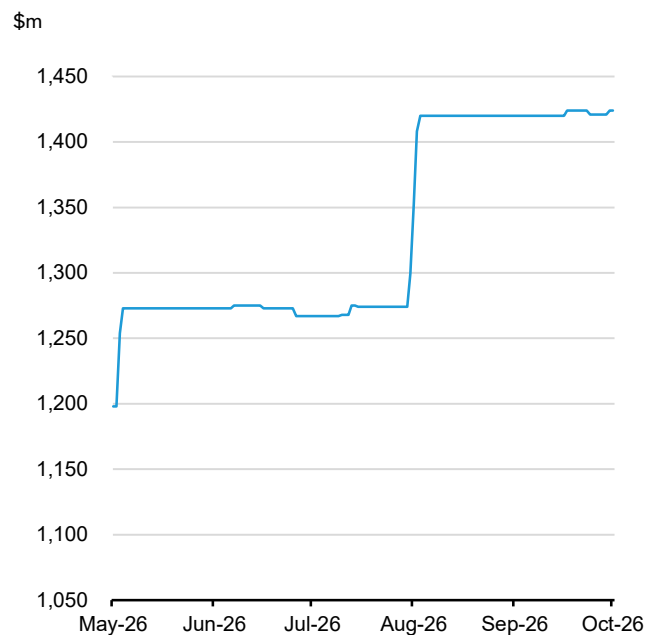
implied guidance midpoint at \$1.41B) and EPS at \$1.39 (VA consensus at \$1.38 and guidance midpoint at \$1.37).

EXHIBIT 11: **NVT share price evolution past 3 months**



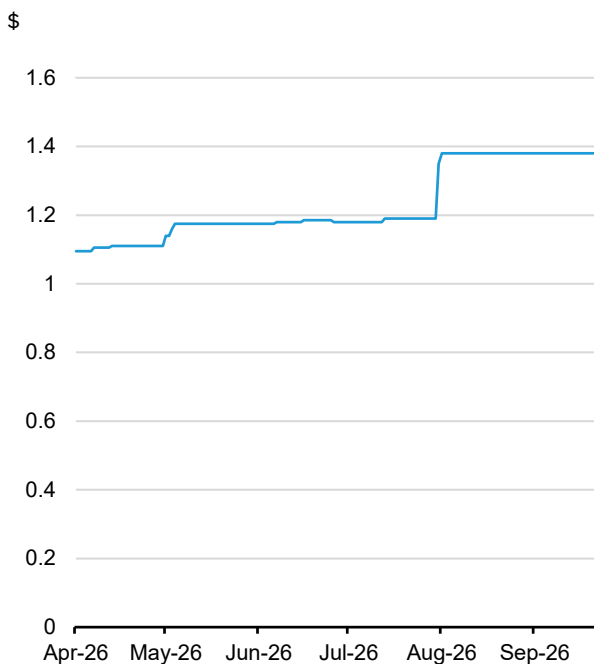
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 12: **NVT Consensus revenue evolution (next reporting quarter)**



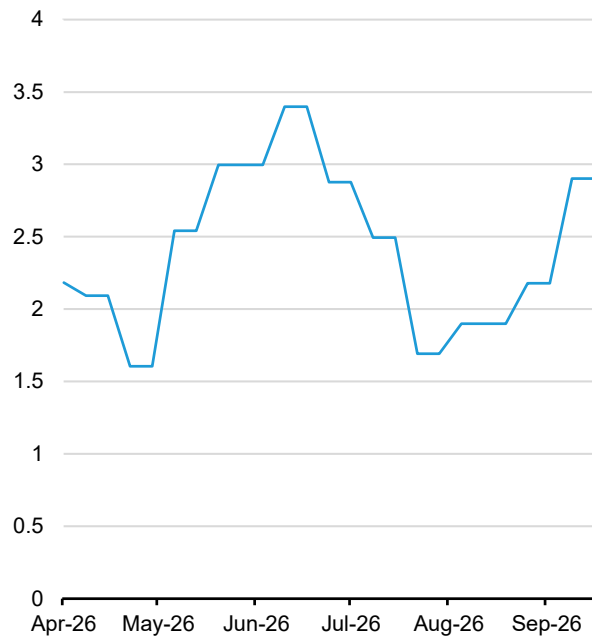
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 13: **NVT Consensus EPS evolution (next reporting quarter)**



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

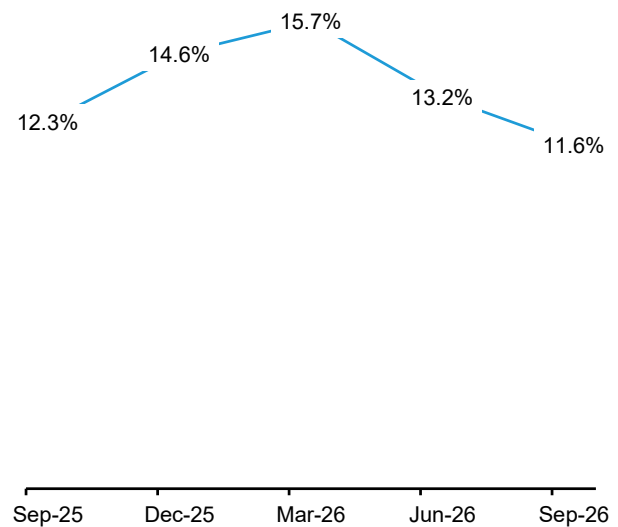
EXHIBIT 14: **NVT short interest as % of total float**



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

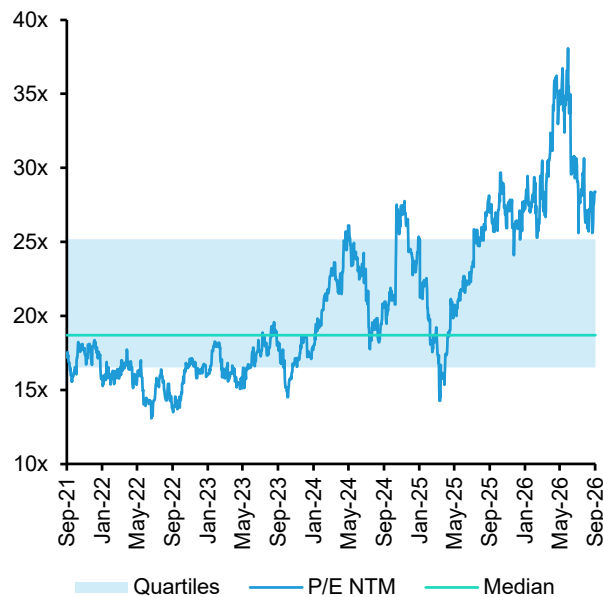
EXHIBIT 15: **NVT hedge fund managers ownership**

Based on publicly reported holdings



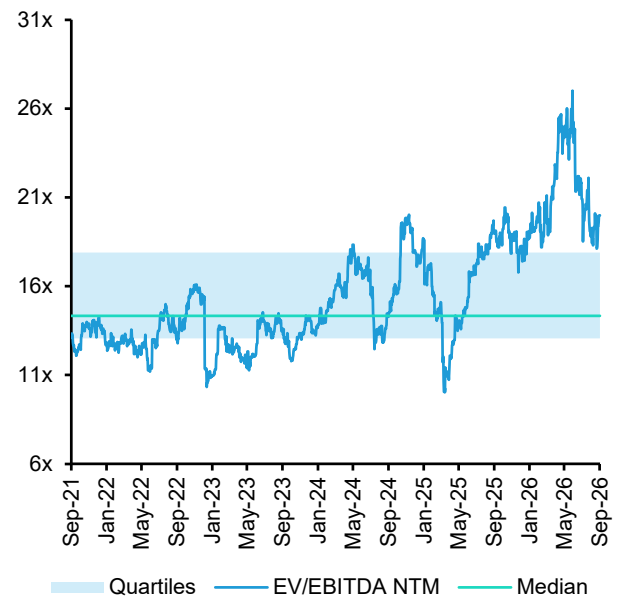
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 16: **NVT P/E NTM**



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

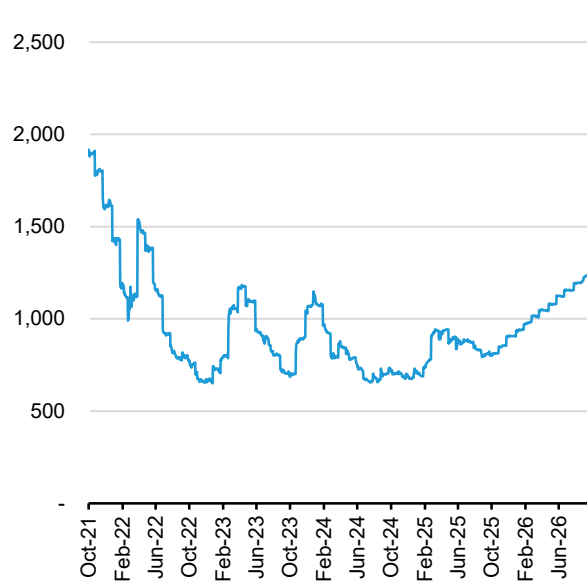
EXHIBIT 17: **NVT EV/EBITDA NTM**



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 18: **US Midwest Hot Rolled Coil (HRC) Steel futures**

USD / Short tonne



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 19: **LME Copper futures**

USD / MT



Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

U.S. MULTI-INDUSTRY & ELECTRICAL EQUIPMENT

EXHIBIT 20: **NVT Cons. vs reported**

\$m

	Revenue reported	Revenue Cons.	Diff (Report. vs Cons.)	Adj. EBIT reported	EBIT Cons.	Diff (Report. vs Cons.)	Dil EPS reported (\$)	Dil EPS Cons.(\$)	Diff (Report. vs Cons.)	Price change on result day
2024 Q3	782	937	-17%	168	212	-21%	0.63	0.81	-23%	-8%
2024 Q4	752	771	-2%	158	159	0%	0.59	0.59	0%	4%
2025 Q1	809	794	2%	162	165	-1%	0.67	0.66	2%	6%
2025 Q2	963	910	6%	200	186	8%	0.86	0.79	9%	15%
2025 Q3	1,054	1,007	5%	213	206	4%	0.91	0.88	4%	10%
2025 Q4	1,067	1,003	6%	210	209	1%	0.90	0.89	1%	-1%
2026 Q1	1,242	1,115	11%	249	217	15%	1.09	0.94	16%	11%
2026 Q2	1,471	1,257	17%	323	261	24%	1.45	1.16	25%	6%

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

I. REQUIRED DISCLOSURES

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